

SEDAR 27A: South Atlantic and Gulf of Mexico Yellowtail Snapper

This assessment produced much lower fishing mortality rates than those of SEDAR 3 for the period covered by that assessment (1981-2001). The management benchmarks were lower for spawning stock biomass and higher for MSY, and the $F_{30\%SPR}$ (F_{MSY} proxy) was intermediate between the ICA and fleet-specific models used in SEDAR 3 (Table 10.6.24). There was a longer time series of data available for this assessment as well as more age information, and there were some discard rate, size-at-release, and estimates of release mortality not available at the time of SEDAR 3. SEDAR 3 used a constant natural mortality rate for its base run of 0.20, and this assessment used a value of 0.194 for M and age-specific natural mortality rates. Discards from the fleets are a large unknown both in quantity and length composition for all of the fleets. There was some data from at-sea sampling on head boats, and there were more limited data from at-sea observers on commercial vertical line vessels that were used by McCarthy (2011b) to estimate the proportion released dead. The gathering of data on released fish (sizes, quantities, disposition at release) is important for all assessments and should be encouraged.

Future assessments on yellowtail snapper may want to re-examine the 1992 MRFSS B2 estimates to look for outliers because the number of estimated discards was anomalously high and had an impact on fishing mortality because of release mortality. Also, the quality and quantity of data gathered after 1991 appears to improve in terms of cv (or PSE) for the MRFSS, and the log book data series provided begins in 1993. Future assessments could restrict the data to 1993 to present, for example, to investigate the impact this restrict data set would have on estimates.